Mani Ratnam, turning in the classic Bollywood set-piece of rambunctious *naach-gaana* atop a moving train. Gulzar dipping into Bulleh Shah to deliver Sufi-pop lyrics; another southie, A.R. Rahman, filling it out with dervish-like energy. Finally, SRK and Malaika Arora doing the honours as if their life depended on that moment of joy. The whole enchillada was savoury enough to become one of the songs India was identified by, sneaking into a Spike Lee film and floating to 9th spot in a BBC poll on 7,000 world music hits.

Monsoon Wedding (2001) inverted the traffic: set in Delhi, but immaculately global in conception. An Indo-American director in Mira Nair; a screenplay penned at Columbia film school; production wallahs from the US, Italy, France, Germany; and yes, the Golden Lion at Venice. There was no truly insular 'Indian culture' anymore—we had joined a vast, throbbing global pool.

ALISHA'S BIGGEST HIT WAS 'MADE IN INDIA', BUT EVEN THAT WAS CLEARLY A RESPONSE TO THE ENORMOUS AMOUNTS OF WORLD CULTURE SLOSHING AROUND THOSE DAYS











HEMANTH PITHWA

POPULAR PULSE Clockwise from left, Alisha Chinai, Shubha Mudgal, Shweta Shetty, Hariharan and Leslie Lewis as Colonial Cousins, and Adnan Sami—voices that carried Indian pop from the margins to the mainstream

Vishal Bharadwaj's *Maqbool* (2003) did it a fourth way: its theme itself is famously from a western source: *Macbeth*. The brooding protagonist, Irrfan Khan, went on to become one of the few Indians to come good in Hollywood. Within Hindi cinema, it joined a new wave with a dark soul, inaugurated by Ram Gopal Varma's *Satya* (1998)—auteurs who clearly knew their film noir and Tarantino.

Look next at pop music. Non-film genres had been colonising